Slowly surveying the crowd of boys who'd come out for football that season, the coach walked down the line, came to me, and looked down: I weighed 108 pounds and stood only five feet, three inches tall.

After a long moment, he said he would see if he had a uniform to fit me.

The next day, the coach said he'd found shoulder pads and a helmet for me, but the school didn't have a regulation pair of pants that were small enough. However—God bless him—somewhere in his attic or some other musty preserve, he'd found an antique pair of football pants with thigh pads made out of bamboo. I'd never seen anything like those pants before, but they fit.

For the next several days I battled as best I could against the bigger boys, but when the day arrived for the coach to announce the team roster, my name wasn't on it. I went home terribly disappointed but determined to make the team during my sophomore year.

When the following summer came, I hadn't grown much larger than I'd been the year before and decided I had to do something fast to build up my muscles for the next season as well as make some money, because I'd decided to start a bank account for my future. With the dual motivation, I got my first job—at thirty-five cents an hour—working with a pick and shovel to help build and remodel houses in and around Dixon.

I learned a lot that summer—how to use my hands, how to lay floors and shingle roofs and work with concrete. I would like to be able to look back on that summer when I was fourteen years old and say I had an unblemished record as a tireless worker, but one incident tarnished the image: At noon one day, as I raised my pick into the air to take another bite out of a stubborn vein of clay, I saw my father approaching our construction site to pick me up for lunch, and at exactly the same moment, the noon whistle blew.